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The Indie Hacker’s Handbook

From idea to paying customers — solo. A no-fluff field guide to building, pricing, and shipping digital products on your own terms.

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01

Why solo is an advantage

The internet rewired who gets to build. One person with a laptop, a payment rail, and a point of view can now reach a global market without permission, inventory, or a boss. This handbook is the field guide for doing exactly that — turning an idea into paying customers, alone.

> *You don’t need a team. You need a loop: make something small, put it in front of real people, learn, repeat.*

Being solo is not a limitation to apologize for. It is leverage. You have no meetings, no politics, and no permission to wait for. Your only real constraints are focus and feedback — and both are things you control.

The three things that actually matter

- A problem people already feel (you are not creating demand, you are finding it).
- A way to get paid that works on day one (not ‘later, once we scale’).
- A loop short enough that you can run it this week.

02

Find a problem worth solving

Most first products fail not because they were built badly, but because nobody needed them. Start from a problem you have personally felt, in a community you are already part of. Proximity is an unfair advantage.

The 20-conversation rule

Before you write a line of code, have twenty honest conversations with people who have the problem. You are not pitching. You are listening for the exact words they use, the workarounds they already pay for, and the moment the pain spikes.

> *If you can finish the sentence ‘I keep paying for X but it still doesn’t Y’, you have found a product.*

Signals that a problem is real

- People already spend money or hours working around it.
- They describe it with emotion, not politeness.
- It recurs — weekly or monthly, not once a year.

03

Build the smallest thing

Your first version should embarrass you a little. If you are proud of it, you waited too long. The goal of v1 is not to be good — it is to be real enough that someone will pay, so you can learn what ‘good’ actually means to them.

Scope it to a weekend

Cut until it hurts, then cut once more. One core action, done well, beats ten half-features. A digital product — a template, a pack, a short course, a tool — is the fastest path, because it delivers instantly and has no marginal cost.

- Pick one outcome your buyer gets.
- Remove every feature that is not on the path to that outcome.
- Ship behind a real payment button, not a waitlist.

04

Price for value, not for time

Pricing is a product decision, not an afterthought. The number you choose signals quality, filters your audience, and decides whether the whole thing is worth your time. Beginners price by hours spent. Pros price by value delivered.

> *Nobody pays you for the hours you spent. They pay you for the hours you save them.*

A simple pricing ladder

- Anchor high with a premium tier so the middle looks reasonable.
- Offer a ‘name your price’ floor for goodwill and reach.
- Raise prices after every ten sales until something breaks.

On a crypto-native rail you also get a quiet superpower: no chargebacks. What you earn stays earned, which changes how confidently you can price and deliver digital goods.

05

Get your first ten customers

The first ten are the hardest and the most important. They will not come from ads. They come from showing up where your buyers already are, being useful in public, and asking directly.

Where the first ten hide

- The exact communities where you found the problem.
- Your own audience, however small — build in public.
- One-to-one outreach to people who said the magic sentence.

> *Do things that don’t scale. Hand-deliver value to ten people and they will tell the next hundred.*

06

Make delivery feel like magic

The moment after payment is where trust is won or lost. The best digital products deliver instantly, clearly, and with a tiny bit of delight. A license key, a download, course access — it should arrive before the buyer has time to doubt.

This is where a modern rail earns its keep: a one-click purchase, an on-chain settlement, and automatic fulfillment mean the buyer gets the thing the instant the payment confirms — no support ticket, no ‘check back later’.

07

Grow without burning out

Solo does not mean alone forever, and it does not mean grinding to zero. Sustainable growth is a flywheel: each product makes the next easier, each customer brings the next, and each system you build buys back your time.

The flywheel

- Ship → learn → raise price → reinvest the time saved.
- Turn repeat questions into the next product.
- Automate the boring 20% that eats 80% of your week.

> *The goal is not to be busy. The goal is to build something that keeps paying you while you sleep.*